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ECR, Vettuvankani - Tel: 044 3526 0300.

Chennai’s little Krishnas and Radhas steal the limelight

More than 1,000 children from across Chennai and the neighbouring districts of Kancheepuram, Tiruvallur and Chengalpattu participated in this edition of *The Hindu Downtown* Maya Kannan

Maya Kannan 2026 authored by *The Hindu Downtown* concluded on a joyous note with the grand prize distribution ceremony held at Gyan Bhawan Auditorium in AM Jain College, Meenambakkam on September 13.

The contest received an overwhelming response with the participation of more than 1,000 children from across Chennai and the neighbouring districts of Kancheepuram, Tiruvallur and Chengalpattu. As part of the Chennai edition which covers the KTCC districts, the contest was organised across five *Downtown* zones, with 13 winners selected from each zone, taking the total number of winners to 65.

The winners were shortlisted after careful evaluation by the jury, with performance, creativity and overall presentation being key considerations. The presence of several children dressed as little Krishna and Radha added a special charm to the occasion, making the selection process particularly challenging for the jury.

After the winners were finalised, they were invited to the prize distribution ceremony along with their parents and families.

The event became an opportunity not only to recognise the young winners but also to celebrate the encouragement and support provided by their families.

The programme began on a graceful note with captivating classical music and dance performances by the talented students of AM Jain School. Their well-presented performances

added a cultural touch to the celebration and were thoroughly enjoyed and appreciated by everyone present. The guests who participated in the inauguration are: P. Suresh Chand Chordia, management committee member, A.M. Jain Educational Institutions, Gayathri, general manager, A.M. Jain Educational Institutions; Vinod Balaji, managing director, Narpavi; S. Ramalingam; insurance advisor and mutual fund distributor; Balaji, store manager, Poorvika Appliances.

The sponsors: The title partner

for the event was Gopuram Turmeric Powder & Kumkum, co presented by Dheepam Lamp Oil, Poorvika Appliances. Associate Partners for the event were Narpavi, S.Ramalingam, Insurance Advisor and Mutual fund Distributor and T.T. Asafoetida. The food partner was Cafe Coffee House, the venue partner was A.M.Jain College. Meenambakkam, Chennai, and the water partner was Repute Water. Gifts were sponsored by Hिलaptop.com. DIFA, Naga food products, P S Tamarind, RAS Chekku Oil, Vivekanandha Sarees and Priyadarshini Cell Universe.

From the event held at AM Jain College in Meenambakkam on September 13. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Winners of Adyar zone



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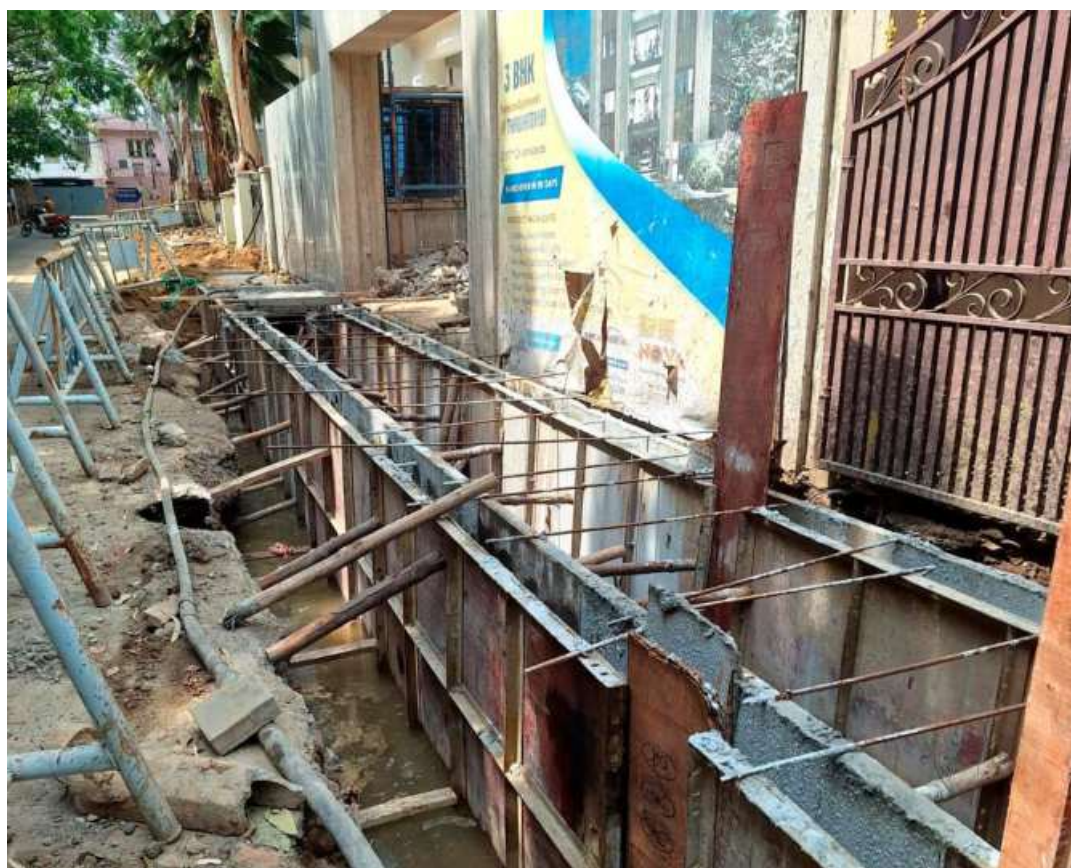


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Thiruvannamiyur residents stage protest over 'faulty' SWD design



On September 17, residents had gathered along Dr. Radhakrishnan Nagar Main Road in Thiruvannamiyur to protest what they termed an ill-baked stormwater drain design being executed on their street by Zone 13 of Greater Chennai Corporation.

Geeta Padmamabhan, general secretary of RMSM, an association established in 2017 to represent residents of Dr. Radhakrishnan Nagar, Marundeeswarar Nagar, Sivakamipuram and Malaviya Avenue in Thiruvannamiyur, notes the project had been initiated following "a petition from those living near the Kalakshetra Road end" complaining of water logging.

"We want them to execute the project only upto the 300-metre mark, and restore the footpath. That should stop flooding at the Kalakshetra Road end," says Geeta. To make way for the SWD project, the footpath had been broken down.

Geeta says: "The height of the new footpath in the making is much above the old one and will be above the property line in some places as they progress."

She points out that a woman from the Marundeeswarar Nagar slum who joined the protest said that the children coming to the three schools on this road would be put to hardship.



During the protest; stormwater drain work on Dr. Radhakrishnan Nagar Main Road in Thiruvannamiyur.

PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

READERS WRITE

'Roads in Velachery need mending'



A battered road in Velachery.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

S. KUMARARAJA

Many roads in Velachery (in Wards 176, 177 and 178) are battered. They are pockmarked with potholes. Further, the stormwater drains are also clogged. All these give room for waterlogging. Greater Chennai Cor-

poration should take appropriate measures such as desilting the drains and mending the roads should be done at the earliest as north-east monsoon will set in, in a few weeks.

S. Kumararaja is the vice-president of Velachery Residents Welfare Associations

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Parking solution sought

Vettuvankeni residents make a plea to Greater Chennai Corporation



PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

PRAMILA IYER

Residents of Vettuvankeni need no statistics to tell them that parking has become a daily trial. A walk down First and Second Avenues, off the East Coast Road, tells the story plainly enough: narrow residential streets lined with cars, footpaths taken over by two-wheelers, and the occasional ambulance or fire tender forced to

inch its way through a gap barely wide enough for a cyclist.

As President of the Vettuvankeni Welfare Association, I have, over the past many months, received a steady stream of complaints from residents on this very subject, and it is time the concern found a wider audience.

Mechanical parking

Given how little vacant land remains within our locality, the conventional answer, which is building

larger surface lots, would not work for us. What Vettuvankeni, and similarly dense pockets along the ECR, urgently need is mechanical (automated) multi-level parking system – compact, vertically stacked structures that use robotic pallets and lifts to park vehicles on a footprint no larger than two or three car spaces.

They can be installed on small odd-shaped plots, including sites the Association could identify near community halls, temples, or unused corners of local parks, without requiring large-scale land acquisition.

(Pramila Iyer is president of Vettuvankeni Welfare Association)

KNOW YOUR NEIGHBOUR

Velachery resident collects Ganesha idols

Lakshmi Prabha, 68, a Velachery resident, came to Chennai in 1989 and began collecting Ganesha idols. Her collection started when she bought her first 12 pieces, finding them reasonably priced. She initially kept the idols as part of her Golu display. One of the first idols that caught her attention was a unique Ganesha wearing a coat. However, the piece was later banned, and she could not find another one like it. In 1998, her daughter gifted her nine Ganesha idols, most of which she had bought from Archies. Lakshmi Prabha also began collecting idols whenever she visited Pudukkottai. Over the years, she has collected around 120 terracotta Ganesha idols.

Among her collection is a paper-holder Ganesha with a crown, which she bought for Rs 40. The response from people who visit



her house and see the collection excites her. This year, she began arranging the collection on Friday at 11 am and continued until 9.30 pm.

The idols in her collection are made from a wide variety of materials, including terracotta, clay, gold, silver, wood, white stone, paper mould, porcelain, glass, cement, brass and black stone.



Lakshmi Prabha with her collection. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Adyar Telephone Exchange stop: no roof, no seats

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Commuters want the Adyar Zone of the Greater Chennai Corporation to make provision for a bus shelter with seating facilities at Adyar Telephone Exchange stop on Shastri Nagar First Avenue. While many commuters sit on the square slab while waiting for buses to arrive, some wait under the banyan trees.

The area behind the haltover is used by people to drink and is dumped with trash, creating an unhygienic environment. Commuters like M. Krithika say the civic body can easily create a decent shelter if the abandoned vehicles around the haltover are removed.

“The area can be cleaned up. The square area can be either barricaded or removed. The food and fish vendors can be relocated nearby,” says M. Krithika, adding that lights are a must at the stop.

J. Devi Jaganathan, a commuter, says some motorists drive rashly and come on the wrong side, putting those waiting on the carriageway at risk.



A long wait at the bus stop.



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Taking a shot at a rare avocation

Dealers of airguns in Chennai note that enthusiasts of recreational airgun target shooting are on the rise

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

A sharp crack followed by a silence probably lasting just a picosecond and therefore going unregistered, and then the loud pop of a balloon bursting from a pellet shot. Those sounds, in that sequence, are heard every day at Marina and Bessie. And usually, to create that sequence of sounds ten times on the trot, with the hire of an air rifle and a balloon target screen, a beach-goer would have to part with ₹50. There are those who seek to make this one-time indulgence a regular habit not by visiting the beach every day, but by a one-time visit to a shop selling airguns.

Welcome to the hobby of recreational airgun shooting which can be practised in a controlled environment at one's own private space. At Asian Air Guns on Perambur Barracks Road, Ashwin Kumar underlines that owning an airgun does not entail getting a license by meeting a fusillade of requirements. That said, there are still requirements to be met. One, the buyer has to be at least 18 years of age and offer proof of identity by presenting a copy of their Aadhar card or driving license. "Aadhar card is preferred," he emphasises.

Another requirement, something that cannot be met by the presentation of a photocopied document, is responsible behaviour. There is discretion to be followed while carrying an air rifle or air pistol. Brandish it in public, and you would find yourself on the wrong side of the law, the act being counted as a punishable offence. While being transported, the airgun has to be carried in a case, covered and hidden from

the public, Ashwin explains.

"When we sell an airgun, irrespective of the price at which it is sold, we take a primer on how to use it, which includes how to use it responsibly. We cannot expect everyone to know the dos and don'ts of it and hence the time, 30 to 45 minutes, we spend educating them," says Ashwin, adding that airgun literacy is indispensable given that target shooting enthusiasts are on the increase. A good number of them take up target shooting away from the glare of the sporting arena because of the quiet benefits it brings to the mind: focus and stress-busting rejuvenation. But an equally good number of them would be cutting their shooting tooth on airguns with the objective of eventually graduating to professional shooting, which involves get-

ting a license. Ashwin likens it to learning to ride a basic scooter before entering a bike race, "If you want to become a bike racer you first learn to ride an Activa."

Besides the logical learning process, there is also economy involved in taking it step by step. He elaborates: "Joining a shooting club and taking up advanced training would automatically lead someone to invest heavily in costly equipment. And what if someone discovers shooting is not their thing after making that investment? Airguns is a

cost-effective way for someone to find out whether shooting is for them or not." And even with an air pistol and air rifle, one could enter a competitive fray, nationally and internationally, as a category with 10M air rifle for men and women and air pistol for men and women exists.

Ashwin brings this perspective to table as he has been on the other side of the counter as well, as a buyer of shooting equipment for his own use, being a licensed shooter and a member of Chennai Rifle Club. In fact, he shares a passion

for shooting with his father S. Ramesh Balaji who established Asian Air Guns in 2005. Both father and son have made a comeback to the shooting range, the former after a 25-year hiatus and the latter, a 10-year break. But as for their business, they want to stick to selling just airguns.

Anna City Armoury also has a history etched with father-son teamwork. Located on Raja Muthiah Road in Periamet, the shop was started in 1993 by T. Selvamani, who had earlier worked with P. Orr & Sons. The "Armoury" in the enterprise's name signifies continuity in Selvamani's professional life. P. Orr & Sons had a link with the armoury business before being associated entirely with horology. The last embers of its identity as a manufacturer and seller of firearms were smouldering in 1967.

Anna City Armoury is run by Selvamani's son, S. Sivabalan, 49, who joined his father while pursuing his degree, and would go on to take over the business entirely after his father's demise in 2015. The shop deals in airguns as well as firearms that require license on the part of the buyer as well as the dealer. Sivabalan admits that the latter, that is selling airguns is the easier proposition. But that is not without its challenges either: one of them is that helped by technology, manufacturers sell directly to consumers with the result that the middle ground occupied by dealers has narrowed.



Airguns on display; airguns at a balloon popping shop in Marina; T. Selvamani founder of Anna City Armoury at Periamet; and Ashwin Kumar of Asian Air Guns at Perambur Barracks Road.



Niche Trades & Hobbies

This section tracks businesses that deal in rare products and follows groups that need those products to keep their hobbies going

Drop your old, unused resources at these spots

'Resource Revival Drive' organised by EcoKonnectors and Spreco is happening on September 27 at various places in and around Mylapore

EcoKonnectors and Spreco are back with another edition of its 'Resource Revival Drive' happening on September 27; 10 a.m. to 4 p.m. Aimed at the festival season, the drive encourages residents to not just clean their home but lend a hand to clean the planet.

The collection drive held in May 2026 saw 1,500 kg of waste collected and sent for responsible recycling. One can bring their old, unused resources a chance to be revived and recycled.

Items that will be accepted include:

- Textiles / Clothes
- Good condition clothes to be collected separately.
- Torn clothes - including undergarments and rags; must be washed and packed separately.
- Electronics (all types of E-waste)
- X-ray films
- Used pens/ toys /stationary
- Empty tablet strips
- Glass bottles (in good condition)
- Books, Toys
- All types of plastics (washed & clean) Hard and soft.
- Footwear in pairs
- Cardboard & paper Bags
- Metal of all types
- Thermocol
- What is not accepted
- Mattresses & Pillows
- Broken Glasses
- Furniture and bulky items
- Wet and Heavily contaminated items
- Puja frames and puja items



Representational picture.

Hazardous and Medical waste

Collection points

- 1) RKNagarra
 - 6/5, Tiruveedhiamman
- Koil St, Ramakrishna Nagar, Raja Annamalaipuram

Contact Bala at 7010848668

2) KARA - Karpagam Avenue Park

4th Street, Next to Pillayar temple, Karpagam Avenue, Raja Annamalaipuram

Contact Bindu Veerabahu at 9176776767

3) Poonga View RWA and Mandaveli Raja Street RWA

Outside Aishwarya Apartments, 29 Raja street extension, Mandaveli, RAPuram

Contact Ravi Subramanian at 94440 76428/ Ganga Sridhar at 9940056069

Three apartments Raga-malika, Raghuvamsh and Ganeshram in RA Puram are also participating in this drive as private collection points for their residents only.

The organisers have requested residents not to leave any waste after the drive is over at any of the drop locations

For details, call 9150003024/ 9940056069



From last year's AGM

RAPRA's AGM today

On the sidelines of the annual general body meeting, there will be shopping facilitated by stalls put up by brands

Raja Annamalaipuram Residents Association (RAPRA) is conducting its 11th Annual General Body Meeting at Rajah Muthiah Boys Higher Secondary School in Srinivasa Avenue, R.A. Puram on September 20 (from 9.00 a.m. onwards). In this meeting members will elect their new office bearers, pass resolutions and fulfill the statutory obligations, says a press release from RAPRA.

Preceding this meeting Bank of Baroda will give a power presentation on their bank's schemes and N Gopaldaas Jewellers will give a presentation on diamond excavation and about the so-called "dosham" in

diamonds. Also on this occasion Lawrence and Mayo opticians will conduct a free eye testing for the visitors. The Government Horticulture Department will sell saplings, compost, seeds and garden tools, the press release notes.

Car dealers, textiles brands, jewellers and dealers of organic vegetables and conditions will put up stalls and sell their products. Stalls are open to the public and it is free. RAPRA will also distribute financial assistance to 40 school students belonging to neighbouring Chennai Schools and Government Aided schools, the release adds.

Free computer education

Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan's Gandhi Institute of Computer Education and Information Technology Centre in Mylapore imparts free computer education to the educated unemployed youth belonging to the economically backward section of the society. Bhavan is offering this selfless service to deserving students in various job oriented computer courses like MS-Office with Tally, DTP, said a release. These courses have helped many students to secure employment at various levels. Senior citizens can now take Microsoft Word, Excel and Internet Courses. Last date for collection and submission of filled application forms is September 26. For more details contact in person. Phone: 24611312, 24643420



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An initiative to recycle clay Ganeshas started by Teynampet resident Malini Kalyanam has impacted many resident groups in Chennai and beyond. Under the aegis of The PALM, headquartered in Tiruvallur, the 'Beautiful Bharat — Save Clay' drive has found volunteer groups across Tamil Nadu

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL



Clay Ganeshas collected at SSM Nagar. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

but supply is on the lower side," she says. Malini says the recycling project has been around for nearly a decade, but awareness has picked up considerably in recent years. With more people asking what they should do with their idols after the festival, the initiative has gradually expanded into a larger conversation about responsible celebration.

Malini, a Teynampet resident who has shifted her base to Tiruvallur for running The PALM, notes that the clay Ganesha idols recycling initiative, titled "Beautiful Bharath — Save Clay" powered by The PALM, has grown bigger, being pan-Tamil Nadu now as volunteers from across the state, which includes P.S. Jayaraman of SSM Nagar, are chipping in. Malini notes plans are afoot to extend the initiative to cities such as Mumbai and Hyderabad.

An extended and green Ganesh Chaturthi

At SSM Nagar in Alapakam, New Perungalathur, residents have been having an extended Ganesh Chaturthi for the last three years, making the clay Ganeshas central to a recycling initiative. As in the previous two years, under an in-house initiative, 'KAATRU' (Keeping Awareness And Action Towards Recycling and Upcycling), helmed by P.S. Jayaraman, has collected clay Ganeshas and kept them ready for potters.

Residents are asked to choose natural, unpainted clay idols and, after the celebrations, leave them at a designated collection point near the Pillayar Kovil. From there, the idols are handed over to potters.

P.S. Jayaraman, a resident of SSM Nagar, initiated this exercise three years ago inspired by a newspaper article about how Malini Kalyanam, pottery artist and environmentalist. "She was in Teynampet. There was a newspaper article saying that Ganesha idols need not be put into water and cause pollution, and that they could instead be given back to potters," he says. The article prompt-

ed Jayaraman to contact Malini, after which the community arranged for its idols to be collected and sent to potters.

The arrangement changed in the second year, when Jayaraman began looking for potters who could directly collect them from the community. "I looked on Google and contacted four or five potters inside Chennai," he says. Eventually, a potter near Kovalam connected him with another potter in Mahabalipuram, who agreed to collect the idols and reuse the material. "From the second year onwards, we started sending the idols directly to him. Last time, we sent around 900 to 1,000 Ganesh-

as," Jayaraman says.

This year, around 200 to 250 idols had already been collected, with residents expected to continue bringing them in until the afternoon of September 19. Jayaraman has also been urging residents to think about their choices before the festival. The campaign asks them to avoid Plaster of Paris idols, non-eco-friendly paints and decorations. "I have been talking only about clay. I have been telling them not to buy painted Ganeshas or plaster Ganeshas," he says.

For Malini Kalyanam, who is Director of the Artistic Pottery Training Academy in Kattupakkam and

one of the founders of The PALM, a public charitable trust, the issue goes beyond what happens to an idol after the festival. As a pottery artist, she has also watched the availability of natural clay decline. This year, her academy received enquiries from corporates as well as members of the public looking to purchase clay for Chaturthi workshops, only to find it difficult to source.

"This year we had enquiries from corporates and the public alike to purchase clay for Chaturthi workshops, and that is when they said it is not available online or even at shops in the locality. This shows that demand is high

An alternative application

Malini Kalyanam notes that if a collection facility or a potter is not available, the clay from the Ganesha idols can be used in tree-planting exercises. She suggests placing the idol in a bucket of water and letting it break down over a few days. Once the clay settles into a powder, it can be reused. However, Malini says, the clay should not simply be poured around a plant or sapling and expected to act as element of nourishment. For it to support plant growth, it needs to be mixed with other materials. She lists the ingredients that mixed with the clay that has dried up as a powder and found impressive results: garden soil, compost, perlite or sand, mushroom molasses and water. The ratio of the ingredients would depend on the sapling, she notes.

DAC launches luxury residences

DAC Developers, one of the city's leading construction companies, recently launched an ultra-luxury residential apartment project, Balmandaisa, on St. Thomas Mount-Poonamallee Road.

At the launch, the company held a logo-revealing ceremony at its Balmandaisa office.

The residential project offers expansive residences, premium amenities and strategic connec-

tivity. It has 194 residences, offering two-and three-bedroom apartments and four-and five-bedroom duplex residences. The residences are complemented by a standalone ground-plus-three-floor clubhouse spanning 10,000 square feet, said a release.

The project comprises two basement levels, stilt, and 13 residential floors, creating a well-integrated residential



community.

The homes are priced from ₹1.19 crore, added the release.

Sathish Kumar Santhanam, founder and managing director, DAC Developers; Kumar Vembu, founder, Mudhal Partners Private Limited and co-founder, Zoho; Hari Vignesh R, senior relationship manager, construction finance; Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited, and Manjunath Selvamani, regional sales manager, Prime Home Loans, Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited, took part.

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